

ALEXKAKAKISED TED

Travel Radio Australia. We're at the World Travel Market in London, which is the industry event for the entire travel industry of the whole world. And I've run into a very interesting guy, Alex Kakalos, who runs a company in the United Kingdom called Business Trends.

And Alex, you were telling me you have a fantastic Australian background. First of all, tell us a bit about Business Trends and what it's about. First of all, yes.

Proud Australian, born in Australia, but grew up in Greece and then returned to Australia when I was 18 or 19 in order to study. Very proud to be Australian and Greek. I think it's one of the best combinations.

I think I'm a bit biased, but anyway. Now I reside in London. I've been living here for the past 12 years.

Business Trends is a company. I work as a management and business consultant specializing in the hospitality industry, but mainly in the food or fast food sector, like helping businesses with startups, even funding if necessary, and existing businesses that want to expand and go into something bigger or a chain. But basically, yeah, that's what I've been doing for the past 12 or more years.

Now, WTM, for those who don't know, World Travel Market, is such a magnificent networking thing. It happens every year. There's 40,000 visitors.

Absolutely huge events. You come here and you're part of the press team here as well. Tell us about your experiences with the WTM, World Travel Market.

It's incredible because, first of all, you get to meet people from basically everywhere in the world, a little bit like Australia, mate. But every country that comes here brings their culture with them, their cultural identity. It's not just about travel and tourism, which is basically what it's all about, but there are many other opportunities that you can discover here by conversing with people, business opportunities, which is what I'm really interested in, because I would like to eventually create and start something within the fast food industry and take it global.

Very interesting. The people you meet, I think it's one... I mean, I really look forward to this every year. It's one of the greatest events, to be fair.

So yeah, we're excited. You were telling me before that when you landed in Melbourne back in the 80s, you were a bit shocked because you had no idea how many Greek people were in Melbourne. Yes, you're right.

Well, I was born in Maitland, New South Wales. So I'm an Australian Greek because I grew up in Greece. My dad moved the family to Greece when I was 10.

So I ended up doing my secondary education in Greece and I returned to Australia in order to study because it was hard to get into a Greek university. You had to be top of the top. I wasn't very studious.

I hated school. So it was easier to get into an Australian university. Sorry to say that, but I could enter just with my HSC certificate or diploma.

There was no need for any further exams or entrance exams. So yeah, I ended up studying at Macquarie University in Sydney, north right. And then I moved to Melbourne at some point where I resided or stayed for another 10 years.

And when I first arrived, correctly so, Geoffrey, I thought I was in another Greek city. I get out of the airport and all I could hear from the cab drivers were Greek. So I don't know what the situation's like now, but then the majority of cab drivers were Greek.

So yeah, an incredible experience. I stayed there for another 10 years and then returned back to Greece. And from there onwards, it's been a journey living and working in different countries.

So yeah, now I'm in the UK, but my heart still belongs in Australia. That's where I was born. And who knows, one day I may end up retiring there for at least six months of the year.

I'm interested with your business trends group. You help people to get off the ground, say they're doing a chain of restaurants or whatever, or takeaway places. Business trends is, well, as a management and business consultancy firm, a lot of small to medium businesses are family run, okay? They don't have a proper structure.

If they want to expand and go into developing a chain, they need to have certain systems in place, which could be duplicatable. You can't duplicate yourself. It's different if you own a restaurant and you're running it yourself and that's it.

But with fast food, you need to have those operational systems and procedures in place. So my job is to start with, if somebody has an existing business, as I said, is to help them move to the next stage. For somebody that wants to open a business in the beginning or from the beginning, I can do everything for them.

I can do the market research, which is necessary. A feasibility study, which follows with a proper business plan, obviously how much money they would require in the beginning. And I can also help them with funding.

So it's interesting. It's challenging. It's challenging because it's not easy.

People think they know everything, unfortunately, and that's why a lot of businesses fail in the first two to three years. And the fast food business is a very competitive business. But I've always learned that to be successful in any business, you need to delegate and you need to have the

right people working for you.

But you need to have those operational systems and procedures in place. Otherwise it won't work, even if you have the best people. So yeah, that's basically what I'm doing now.

And my life from now onwards is to move and create business ventures in different countries. And that involves so much travel. And the thing here, Greece is actually sponsoring our international media center that we are sitting in at the moment.

And give us a couple of, for our American listeners and the Australian listeners who haven't been to Greece, give us a couple of your favorite places that you would really highly recommend. Well, that's a very good, very good question. I mean, everybody thinks of Greece in terms of the islands, probably 3,000 or more islands.

It would be impossible to visit all the islands. You'd have to live for 3,000 years unless you get some luxury yachts and you cruise most of the islands within a certain period of time. But the Greek mainland is incredible.

And I come from the north of Greece, from the real Macedonia. My parents come from northwest Macedonia, not far from Thessaloniki, which is the capital of Greek Macedonia. Macedonia in Greece is a geographical region, a prefecture if you'd like, the biggest in Greece.

And the capital is Thessaloniki, which is a beautiful city. It's the second largest city after Athens. But Greece is very mountainous.

It's probably the most mountainous country in Europe per square kilometer. So you have that contrast of mountains and sea, which is incredible. But it's the cultural aspect of Greece, which is more interesting, and that you will find in the mainland.

The islands are okay, but they're very touristic. And it's like, I prefer personally to go to the non-touristic islands, which are more laid back where you get to see the real Greek culture. I suppose I'm a little bit biased, but Boris Johnson gave a speech in New York not too long ago at some forum, and he spoke about Greece.

He said, Greece gave us everything. And he started talking about all the things like democracy, philosophy, arts, theatre, Olympic Games, what have you. But he said, one thing Greece did give us that you're probably not aware of is Rome.

And he was right. So Romans took everything from the Greeks, and then England took basically everything from the Greco-Roman civilization. And then he ended up saying, and England gave us the USA.

That's a very good story. Which is true. I mean, the American culture or the foundation is British.

Now it's of course changed a lot. Australia is pretty much the same. So if you go back to where it all started, the cradle of Western civilization is Greece.

So proud to be Greek, but proud to be Australian, man, because I mean, growing up in Australia was an incredible experience. And of course, going back in my early teens, as I said, I probably will end up retiring there one day and or living there six months of the year. Who knows? And can you say hello in Greek to our Greek Australian friends who are listening across the country? Yeah, of course I can.

Well, Alex Kakalos from Business Trends UK, thank you so much for being on the program and saying hello to all of our Greek friends in Australia. It was a pleasure meeting you, Jeff. And g'day, mate.

One last thing I wanted to say, it's funny because you all know of Ange Postekoglou, very proud to have him represent Australia and Greece. And I used to say to people, well, you know, Ange is a Greek Australian or a Greek Aussie. I'm an Aussie Greek.

His family moved to Australia when he was five. And my family moved us to Greece when I was 10. So different avenues, but, you know, great, great sportsman and very proud to have him here in the UK.

Thank you, Alex. And thanks for being on the show. Thank you.

You're most welcome, my friend. Yassou. Yassou.